



▲ Dark deity

This human skull, covered in a mosaic of turquoise and lignite, is believed to represent the Aztec god Tezcatlipoca. Probably worn on the back as an ornament, it has been dated to the 1400s or early 1500s, during the height of the Aztec civilization.

THE SMOKING MIRROR

Aztec sorcery

In 1521, Spanish forces under Conquistador Hernán Cortés conquered the mighty Aztec Empire, which had dominated present-day central and southern Mexico since the 1400s. The Empire's beliefs were a blend of different Mesoamerican cultures, such as that of the Maya people, and their practices included a roster of deities, rituals, superstitions, divination, and spells. With the Spanish conquest came the conversion of indigenous people to Christianity. Much information about Aztec culture has been filtered through the viewpoints of the Spanish colonizers, or of those who were converted to Christianity. One such source is the *Florentine Codex*,

created by Spanish missionary Bernardino de Sahagún along with indigenous helpers. Sahagún arrived in Mexico just after the Spanish conquest. While the colonizers often feared the customs they encountered and saw them as magical, they in fact represented the Aztec religion; Christianity, no doubt, would have seemed like sorcery to many Aztecs.

Gods and sorcerers

Two of the principal Aztec gods were Tezcatlipoca and Quetzalcoatl. Tezcatlipoca literally means "smoking mirror," giving this deity his nickname, "Lord of the smoking mirror." He is often shown



► Double power

This serpent was probably worn as a chest decoration during Aztec ceremonial rites. The double-headed snake spelled bad luck and, at worst, imminent death.